for the Proteas and has since become a successful head coach at the Titans.

Having a fighting spirit could mean subscribing to the belief that, when you are involved in any kind of game, you play as if it is the most important thing in the world, sure in the knowledge that as soon as the final whistle sounds and it's all over that very same game becomes the least important thing in the world.

It's only sport, people might say, and they're right, but it is sport and, during the game, there is no alternative but to strain every muscle and fight for every single inch. You need to fight like hell, you need to fight like Rafa Nadal so often fights on the tennis court, you need to fight like Tiger Woods fought through the intense pain in his left knee when he somehow managed to complete the 2008 US Open, and actually won the title.

Being able to have fun means being able to do all of the above while still retaining the capacity to sit back every once in a while, to share a beer with your mates and just enjoy yourself. In my experience, the world-class sportsman who has most effectively and most consistently got this part right is Ernie Els.

Ernie is recognised around the world as a great golfer, with two US Open wins, two British Open wins and 64 other professional titles to his name in a career that started way back in 1989; and he has made enormous contributions in the fields of autism and golf for underprivileged youngsters in South Africa. Above all, however, he remains the same big easy guy with the big easy swing, the big easy smile and the soft heart.

By a happy coincidence, Ernie and John Swart, my father-in-law, both own holiday homes in Herolds Bay, not far from George on the southern coast of South Africa, and, in recent years, we have been able to spend a couple of days in that part of the world between the Christmas and New Year Test matches.

One day in 2012, Danielle and I had been out to lunch and were returning home when I saw a tall, blond man driving his car, and seemingly arriving at his house, and thought he looked familiar.